

Binge Eating Disorder

What is Binge Eating Disorder?

Binge Eating Disorder (BED) is a serious eating disorder characterised by someone having regular episodes of binge eating. BED is diagnosed when binge episodes occur at least **once a week** for **three months** or more. People with BED often experience a lot of distress about their binge eating.

A binge eating episode involves:

- Eating a much larger portion of food than most people would eat in one sitting (e.g., at least 2-3 times more than usual for a typical meal or snack)
- Eating this large portion within a short period of time (usually within 2 hrs)
- Feeling out of control and finding it hard to stop when eating

During a binge eating episode, people may...

- Feel an overwhelming urge to eat and may become fixated on food
- Eat more quickly than normal
- Eat until they feel uncomfortably full
- Eat large amounts of food even if they are not feeling physically hungry
- Eat alone or in secret due feeling embarrassed or ashamed

Binge eating is different to overeating. Overeating is when we eat more than we normally would, but don't feel out of control. Many people overeat from time to time and this is not considered disordered eating. Binge eating is different because of the feeling of **loss of control** and **not being able to stop**.

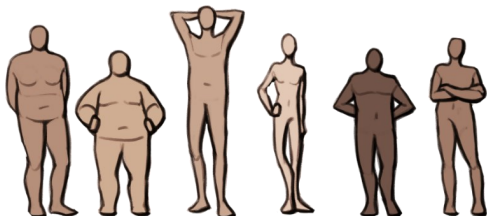
Binge eating is also more associated with strong negative feelings (such as guilt, shame, and sadness) than overeating. For people with BED, these binge eating episodes have a severe impact on their psychological wellbeing and functioning. For more information on binge eating episodes, please see our handout [Binge Eating](#).

Who can be affected by BED?

According to the National Eating Disorders Collaboration, BED is the most common eating disorder, affecting about half of all people with eating disorders.

BED can affect anyone regardless of gender, age, cultural background, or socio-economic status. Many people with BED do not receive treatment or reach out for help, despite it being the most common eating disorder. People have reported feeling shamed, dismissed, and guilty because of their eating disorder, and this has been a main barrier when accessing help.

It is important to remember that people of all genders, ages, cultural backgrounds, socio-economic status, as well as all body shapes and sizes can experience eating disorders. Your body size doesn't determine whether or not you may be diagnosed with BED and all people are worthy of help.



Impacts of BED

BED can have serious effects on physical health and psychological wellbeing. Regular binge eating can lead to unstable blood sugars, disrupt hunger and fullness cues, and make it difficult to maintain stable weight in whatever range is best for your body. It can also lead to liver dysfunction and increased acid reflux.

BED can also be associated with strong negative thoughts and emotions. People with BED often feel distressed by their eating, which fuels their self-criticism and feelings of guilt, shame, and disgust. This can then increase the chances of someone engaging in future binge eating, keeping them caught in this vicious cycle.

Due to these negative feelings, people with BED may withdraw from social activities and their relationships. Lots of people with BED report being unhappy with their body weight or shape, and many people with BED report having a long history of dieting or other disordered eating behaviours. See our handout on [Why Diets Do Not Work](#).

Due to these significant physical and psychological consequences, it is important for people with BED to access treatment and support.

Treatment for BED

According to the [NICE Guidelines](#), Cognitive Behavioural Therapy (CBT) is the leading evidence-based treatment for BED in adults. Treatment involves learning to understand your eating patterns, why binges occur, then developing strategies to help reduce your binge eating. To learn more, you can read our [Orientation to Treatment](#) handout. Although it can be challenging, a full recovery is possible and very worthwhile.

Some benefits of recovery include:

- Learning new helpful strategies to cope with emotional distress
- Improved mood and reduced anxiety
- Better body image and more body acceptance
- Reduced preoccupation with food, and body weight and shape
- Improved physical health and wellbeing
- A greater understanding of your own thoughts and feelings, and how they contribute to behaviours
- Less fear around avoided or common binge foods



You can access our free CBT self-help workbook [Break Free from ED](#) to learn strategies to reduce binge eating and help with an eating disorder.

Other steps you can take to help you manage your BED:

- Eat regularly, adequately, and include a variety of foods
- Learn to cope with uncomfortable feelings. Please see our useful self-help workbook [Facing Your Feelings](#).
- Seek support from your GP, a 'Health At Every Size' dietitian, or a psychologist who understands eating disorders.

Please note that this handout is not a substitute for treatment for BED; it is a serious eating disorder. If you or someone close to you has signs of an eating disorder it is important to see a GP and discuss seeking help as soon as possible.